

Windows NT was just Windows 3.1 based on a different kernel. NT 4.0 looked more recognisable, like Windows 95 and 98

Which finally brings us to the current generation of Windows. Despite all its faults, Windows Vista was a major update to the Windows platform, and brought Windows to v6.0. Now since we have already established that we all here know math, it would make sense to assume that Windows 7 would be, at its core, Windows NT 7.0; well your assumption would be wrong. Windows 7 is, believe it or not, based on Windows NT 6.1. We'll be the first to admit that version numbers are mostly meaningless, but it's still a bit odd. If you don't believe us, just start any core Windows application, like paint or notepad, and check out its about page, on Windows 7 you will see it listed as "Version 6.1".

Now you may be wondering why this is important. This is important, because with Windows 8, we have another major change, perhaps the most major change to Windows yet. Windows 8 finally fulfils the promise of Windows NT as a kernel that can run on multiple platforms, by embracing ARM. Another interesting development with Windows 8 is the merger of the Mobile and Desktop versions of Windows, just like there was the merger of the Windows NT and Windows 9x back in 2001 with the release of XP.

Windows NT 6.2 now runs on desktops and laptops as Windows 8, on servers as Windows Server 2012, on tablets as Windows RT, and on phones as Windows Phone 8.

Even this isn't the only architectural change to come to Windows. Windows 8 introduces completely new kinds of Windows applications. Earlier called "Metro"-Style applications, now they're just called Modern-style applications. These applications can only be installed from the Windows Store – unless you are a company and need to run private apps.

Just like the Win32 API was introduced way back with the release of Windows NT in 1993, Windows 8 introduces WinRT, a new simplified set of APIs for Windows that has been developed for the new modern style of applications